FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Elderly village women on the edge of the Thar desert, whose sole interaction with energy was through dry twigs and cowdung, are being turned into solar champions. In bone-dry Saurashtra, dozens of new lakes have been blooming. A pristine Aravalli forest has grown from scratch in the middle of Gurugram, one of India's most haphazardly growing hypercities. A couple helps sustainable ecosystems blossom in the harsh landscape of peninsular India; their very mention brings a smile to thousands of tribal farmers. A non-profit in Bengaluru that calls itself Janaagraha, or 'the wish of the people', has made inspired citizen participation central to urban solutions: urgent tasks, such as battling the traffic chaos in India's Silicon city, are brought within the ambit of collective oversight. A motley set of actors, operating in quite diverse realms, but all have one thing in common. They are a sampling of stellar individuals and institutions doing transformative work at the exact place where it is the hardest: the last mile. But they are doing it quietly, beyond the glare of headlines and hashtags, even as their work merits comparison with the best global benchmarks. Across sectors as varied as healthcare, education, ecology, justice, urban governance and agrarian livelihoods, these outstanding endeavours have built organisations and movements that value rigour over rhetoric, outcomes over options and dignity over dependency. They have become forces that generate a greater good, and goodwill.



▲ **Aug. 21, 2017**

In this Republic Day special issue, we feature 20 such institutions, with their individual protagonists who have reproduced their vision in the unforgiving laboratory of real life. Some have earned a wider renown, partly because of the more universal impact of their work. Like cardiac surgeon Devi Prasad Shetty of Narayana Health, whose self-given mandate of affordable healthcare is animated by the simple credo that all the advancements in medicine would be meaningless if not delivered to "the common man". Aravind Eye Hospital in Madurai replicates that vision in its own subfield; it has gained visibility by dint of a battle against 'needless blindness' that has now run for half a century. The India Health Fund's vital work in reducing the disease burden across the country is enabled by the fact that it stands on the shoulder of a giant, the Tata Trusts. But in our mix are also those gaining stature on their own. Like former IT professional Prasad Bhide in Pune, whose encounter with the vacuum in eldercare during his own mother's senescence sparked Aaji Care, devoted to assisted living for the old, marrying enterprise with conscience.

We take that varying scale of visibility to all domains, recognising rather than penalising success, but also shining a torch on those whose fame is limited to their chosen field; even if it impacts millions, these remain microcosms in the larger scheme of things. For instance, Sanjit Bunker Roy's Barefoot College, in Tilonia, Rajasthan, has a transformative potential way beyond the innumerable rural lives it has touched, creating those 'solar mamas'. The Dholakia Foundation's Mission 100 Sarovar has finished creating 75 ponds till now. But businessman Savjibhai Dholakia's idea of scaling that up to revitalise entire river systems is one all of India urgently needs. Many institutions we have chosen intervene on that complex development canvas, encompassing livelihoods and ecologies. The 1967-born BAIF Development Research Foundation in Pune, for instance, brings together two natural companions, food security and climate resilience. The work of Aranya Agricultural Alternatives, a mission born to the Narsanna and Padma Koppula couple in 1987, touches not only the tribals of Andhra/ Telangana but also worldwide enthusiasts interested in how permaculture can transform arid environments. A different kind of degraded aridity was the focus of ecologist Vijay Dhasmana's miracle: an abandoned mine in the heart of Gurugram is now a biodiversity park, rewilded with native flora, real estate for avian and four-legged fauna.

Many of them operate in India's most difficult contexts: in remote villages, amid fragile ecosystems and marginalised communities. Some venture into areas left fallow despite decades of policy. Like Pratham, which is setting benchmarks for quality education. Some come in where even the justice system often fails: a Majlis Legal Centre, for instance, offers crucial judicial and other forms of support to victims of domestic violence and sexual abuse. Some work in tandem with official systems, like the Akshaya Patra Foundation that now provides free midday meals to 2.35 million children across states. Strewn among these are hidden treasures like the Ecotourism and Conservation Society of Sikkim that is revitalising the rural landscape with its vision of sustainable tourism and water management, or the National Research Centre on Equines that's striving to save rare Indian horse breeds. This issue is a special collection, curated with care from a longer list of worthy institutions, to make it representative across sectors and regions. We are calling them the Gems of India, all of them polished with inspiration and perspiration. Not only does their lustre illumine us, they offer templates worth replicating. Meaningful revolutions that are making our Republic stronger, they are awaiting not applause or recognition but emulation.

(Aroon Purie)